

I would love to tell you that climbing [music] is complicated, but you're missing something specific, a strategy, a concept, a way of thinking, then once you find it, everything changes. That would make for such a good video, and I'm sure it would go viral if I had the fix to becoming an apex tier gamer, but it's not real. Although I spent 2 hours talking to somebody, and went pro in Counter-Strike, in Challenger in League of Legends, and he never spent longer than 3 months in a single tier. And from what he told me, he's just a regular person, he's not some genius or an incredible talent. In the time I had with him, I tried to figure out what separates him from the thousands of players who are putting in the same hours and going nowhere, [music] like myself. Once I started applying these things, it made me a much better player and a much better learner. Here are the eight core lessons from our conversation. >> The way I played the game for like, I guess since like the very like start, was just with this idea of like, I just don't want to be bad. I'm just really sick of this. I I like I just I hate being bad at things, right? And I was like, okay, well, what do I have to do to not be bad at at this, right? >> Most players hate losing. Very few hate sucking, and those are not the same thing. Hating to lose is about the outcome. It is emotional, it's about what other people see on the scoreboard. It fades when the next game starts. Hating to suck, on the other hand, is about the process. It's about knowing privately that your decision was wrong, that you made a mistake, and that you weren't good enough. That does not fade when the next game starts. It carries forward until you fix it. Players who hate losing will do almost anything to avoid the feeling. Blame the teammates, switch champions, blame the game, take a break. Players who hate sucking will do almost anything to find the cause. That distinction is not small. It is the entire difference between someone who plays for years and stays the same rank, and someone who reaches the top of two separate games. You just get mad, right? Like I just got mad. I was just pissed all the time about it. Like whenever I Every time I'd play the game, not all the time literally, but like every time I play the game, I'm like, "This sucks. I hate this game. I'm so sick of this crap." And I'm like, "I'm sick of playing in bronze or like gold at the time." And I'm like, "I don't want to I don't want to be in gold anymore. This sucks. This is awful." That feeling, that specific uncomfortable intolerance for being bad, is the engine that will continually make you better day by day. >> They've been there forever. They have no desire to get better. Or or they act like they have the desire to get better. And those are the people who piss me off the most are people who act like they're they're like, "Dude, I'm so close to getting better. I'm so close to getting better. I'm I'm like literally locking in, dude." I'm like, "No, no, no. I know what locking in looks like, my my [__] platinum friend this year Goku." Dude, he's writing notes after every game on matchups. And he is climbing. >> The pretending problem. There is a psychological phenomenon that explains why most players have no idea why they're stuck. It is called Dunning-Kruger effect. I know it is simple. The level of competence required to recognize what you're doing wrong is the same level of competence you have not yet reached. Which means that the players who need the most improvement are the exact same players who are least equipped to see

it. But here's what makes that worse in practice. Pretending to practice is not practicing. Playing games is not improving. And the gap between those two things is where most players live permanently. Convinced that they're doing hard work because they're putting in the hours, but what they're actually doing is going through the motions they've already automated. Automation feels like skill. It is not. Automated mistakes are still mistakes. They're just comfortable ones. So before anything else, the question is not how many hours did you put in? The real question is whether those hours are requiring anything from you. >> I think for me a lot of the time it is just like learning through [__] up and just getting punished for it, right? >> Yeah. >> The the you know, [__] around and find out method. >> Yeah. >> Um which like, you know, honestly, like I think that's a really big part of what people are missing now and >> He did praise deliberate practice, but what he also did was praising [__] around and find out. But he did it with intention. He played for understanding, not for copying. When you make a mistake, you doesn't justify. He feels it. So, feel the mistake, not explain it, don't justify it, not immediately move to the next game. Feel it. That sounds simple, but it's really not. Feeling a mistake requires you to accept that it was a mistake in the first place, but fully, without the buffer or the blame or context. And that is genuinely uncomfortable. That is also why most players do not do it. They've developed an extraordinary ability to locate the other variable, the teammates, the match-ups, the patch, the lag, fast enough that the discomfort never fully lands. Problem is that the discomfort is the signal. It is your brain marking something as this needs to change. When you move the pain, you remove the marker. And a mistake with no marker attached is a mistake that you'll make again tomorrow and the day after that. He also told me to stop looking at content for answers, you know, lacking information, you're avoiding the work. >> I think one thing I really stayed away from that I that I think and I I'll recommend to anyone is stay away from general coaches. Um stay away from like coaches in general on on like YouTube. >> This one I really felt personally, not just with League, but with content creation, because I spent hours watching videos and guides trying to learn, but what I was actually doing was consuming. I wasn't learning. Those are two completely different activities. Consuming feels productive. It is low friction, you sit back, somebody explains, you nod, nothing is really required of you, which is why it's actually entertainment, not learning. Learning requires you to be wrong about something first. You wouldn't know what to do. Think about that for a second. You know your biggest mechanical weakness? You know the decision you keep getting wrong? You know the habit that is costing you games? The next video, the next guide, the next tier list is not going to tell you something that you don't already know. It is going to give you a temporary feeling of progress without the permanent cost of making the change. That is a cheat code you're looking for and it doesn't exist. This is a big reason why it took so long to make this video cuz I kept looking to how to make it better, how to get better at editing, how to record better, but the truth is just doing the thing is ultimately the thing that is going to make me better. This video is not going to be perfect, but I am doing it and I'm learning. He drew a

distinction that I think is one of the most underrated ideas in competitive gaming. There is a difference between copying what pro players do and understand why they do it. Copying is mimicking the output, learning is internalizing the input. >> If you if you do that, it's just not going to work out cuz that also implies that you can learn everything exactly how everyone else learns and that's just not how life works. And you're going to be really sad when you find out that you can't that you're screwed. And you've just wasted a bunch of time for zero reason. >> Copying breaks the moment the situation changes. You copy the answer, not the reasoning. So when a new question appears, you got nothing. Learning survives context. When you understand why something work, why that positioning is correct, why that timing is right, why that engage is good, you can apply it to situation you've never seen before and this is going to happen in every game all the time because they're so complex. This is what he calls theory versus concept. Concept is a set of rules that is tailored to specific situation. If the enemy team does X, you do Y. >> [music] >> But, concept completely breaks apart when the situation changes. The theory adapts. He explained the difference between challengers and everybody else like this. So, he said that challenger players, they view the game holistically, whereas everybody else kind of sees the games in steps and in concept, a set of rules. If they do this, I do Y. And so on. Whereas pro players, they will know just intuitively and they will adapt to every situation every second of the game and not see it as because I am this champion, I need to win this way. That's not a thing. So, instead of having a list of rules for the game, he has model for the game on how he views it. Difference is not talent. The difference is the question you ask yourself when you review your games. What should I have done there? Is a concept question. It gives you an answer for the next time the same situation appears. Why was that decision wrong? Gives you principle you can apply everywhere. The goal trap. Callous reached challenger very quickly. But, he told me that making challenger your goal is one of the most reliable ways to never get there. >> But, just just pick something that's not being challenger. Please, for the love of God. Or or something that's not 10 ranks up from you. Please, if you're bronze, don't make your goal [__] diamond. At max, make it like platinum. Please, don't do that. You're going to get very demotivated if you realize, oh my God, I just hit platinum and it took me 200 games. >> Do not make challenger your goal. It will lead to overwhelm, to look for hacks, to dramatic changes. It demotivates you every game you're not there. The space between where you are and challenger is so large, it creates two specific failure modes. First, you're going to look for shortcuts. You're going to look for things that can collapse the distance fast, and you champion a broken strategy, a coach session that reveals the one thing you were missing. The distance feels so large for incremental efforts that you're going to look for non-incremental. It doesn't exist. Second, every game that does not feel like meaningful progress feels like failure, which is almost every game. So, that means you're playing in a constant low-level state of inadequacy. Instead, consider comparing yourself to who you were last week or last game. That gap is small enough to see it clearly, and closing it

consistently is the only path to anywhere worth going. >> So, to get I I genuinely am of the belief that anyone can hit masters. I want to say masters was the Elo I was in the longest, and it was 3 months. >> Anyone can hit masters, not because it's easy, but because the path is simple enough that if you execute it generally consistency, the outcome follows. The complexity people imagine is almost entirely self-generated. And then there's a line that stuck with me for almost the entire situation. If you try 100% in every game, you're already better than most. That's not a motivational quote, it's an observation about the actual population of players in ranked queues. Most players are not fully present in most games. One eye on the outcome, one foot already out the door when it starts going wrong, half committed, waiting to see if there's a winnable game before they decide whether to fully engage. Complete presence, actual 100% in every game, is so much rarer than you think, and it is available to you right now without learning a single new mechanic. >> Poker isn't about playing the odds. It's about playing the man. [music] >> The meta game. Everything we've covered so far is internal. How you practice, how you think, what you measure. This chapter is about something most players never even consider, the the human on the other side of the screen. >> Really common thing actually in in Counter-Strike is like fakes, right? So, you like fake going a certain way or maybe you go to A every single round, right? Because it's just working. And then they stack A and then you go to B. >> In League, the best players are not just playing the game, they're reading the human decisions inside it, their tendencies, their emotional state, their decision pattern under pressure. The opponent is an actual person. They have a champion that they're uncomfortable playing against, that play style that makes them hesitate, a tilt trigger, a pressure threshold past which their decision-making severely drops. And we've all seen this in our own teammates and in ourselves. >> Like, let me tell you what. You want to see someone tilt off the face of the planet? You sit there and you go to the enemy raptors and you hex flash on repeat over someone's raptor walls or you just straight flash level one. >> Playing into those things is not cheap. It is actually high-level. And ignoring it means you're the only person at the table who doesn't know the game being played. The worst feeling in League of Legends is helplessness. Feeling like nothing you do matters. The best players do not just avoid that feeling themselves, they deliberately create it in their opponents. >> So many people's tilt and so many people's like frustration in this game comes from feeling helpless. There's no worse feeling than feeling helpless. And like that's that's that's my entire gameplay style, dude. It's literally just like, why is this Rumble sitting here? Please, someone do something. >> Agency is valuable. When you feel like your decisions have consequences, you play better. When you feel like nothing you do matters, you deteriorate. The best players maintain their own sense of agency through any game state, and they actively try to sabotage the enemy's agency. Everybody knows players tilt, but almost nobody plays to tilt people. Mental warfare is real and is simply underused. And then there's winning ugly. >> There's no right way of winning. You're winning. That's the thing is like if I get the LP, dude, I've won. That's all I care about. >> A

win that looks bad is still a win. Players only respect clean victories, are optimizing for aesthetics and not outcomes. The ability to grind out a win when everything is going wrong is a skill. The ability to stay functional when the game is ugly, when your team is flaming, when you're behind, but still finding a path to win is a skill that most players never develop because they're out of the game mentally before it's actually over. When it comes to your own mental state, do not suppress, release. There's a big difference. Suppression means swallowing it and carrying it forward. Release means letting it exist completely, briefly, and then setting it down. Players who handle pressure the best are not the ones who feel the least, they're the ones who process faster. Number one, stop watching Challenger games. If you're not in Challenger, stop watching Challenger games. The decision-making, the macro, the interactions, they're built on a foundation you do not have yet, and you're watching a completely different game. >> You're You're not a Challenger player, your teammates, you know, aren't Challenger players. So, if you watch a Challenger game, it does not necessarily mean that [laughter] your teammates are going to understand the angle. Like, >> The mechanical gap between low elo and high elo is so large that the decision-making you see in pro play is not editable without the foundation. You cannot import conclusion without the reasoning, and the reasoning requires the foundation. >> Watch players that are maybe one or two tiers above you. That gap is going to be just close enough for you to be able to close it, and that game is going to be the same one you're playing. >> Number two, mechanics before macro. If you're below platinum, your macro is not what's losing your games, your execution is. The correct call, executed poorly, loses to the wrong call, executed well. This is especially important because the macro knowledge in lower ELOs will have a much bigger variety. So, relying on your teammates to make the right decisions is going to sabotage you, whereas mechanical skill can adapt to any situation. Even if you know the right place to do Baron or to do dragon or do this execution on Counter-Strike, it does not matter because your teammates won't be able to do it. Whereas, if you can just shoot well in Counter-Strike or you can apply your mechanics really well in League of Legends, get the kill and get out, get gold, and then play for the next good macro play for your team, that's going to be a much more reliable way to climb than trying to be a leader for a team who does not know what they're doing. Number three, play aggressively. It's really hard to teach a player who's innately safe playing to be aggressive comparative to teaching an aggressive player to play safe. Aggression is a skill. Passivity is a habit. Passive players tend to spend years rewarding their hesitation. They need to unlearn something deeply ingrained. Aggressive players just need direction. >> [clears throat] >> The raw material is already there. If you're passive by default, play aggressively this week and comfortably so. You're going to make a mistake, and that is the point. The mistakes will teach you the boundaries that we talked about earlier. If you never make any mistakes, you're never going to improve. The basics you're ignoring. >> Try to take care of yourself. Take a drink, right, of water. Like, if you're if you're like literally anything can slow you down by 1%, that adds up quick. 10 10 factors

of 1% is still is 10%, right? Like, that's 10% less than you could be. So, it's like and and that sounds like kind of I guess like almost overly serious, but it's true. >> Take care of the basics. Water, food, posture, sleep, no phone on the desk, gym if possible. That's not soft suggestions. They're great up performance boosters. Not even boosters, they're requirements. You cannot perform a cognitive peak on 4 hours of sleep. Phone buzzing beside you. The mental performance ceiling that you're trying to reach requires a biological foundation that you're not maintaining. Make one change this week. Put your phone in the other room. Return your first second monitor. Drink more water. Focus on your sleep. Do one of these things and you're going to notice a difference. The research on divided attention is not ambiguous. You're much worse than you think when the option to check something else exists. Checking that without one Discord message, changing your music song. Those are big distractions and it's hurting your gameplay, not just in the moment, but for the next few minutes. And that can mean a win or a loss. >> I was so locked in at what at that point that I actually I took names off in game. >> Carlos turned off name plates in the game because he knew it improved his reaction time. Studies show that when humans have text, they're going to focus on it and it's going to make your reaction time much slower. That is why advertisers and some reels actually use text as subtitles, even if you know the language. It's not to help you understand, it's actually just to hook the attention and keep it there. >> Details matter. >> Small deliberate adjustments compound. Not because each one is large, but because the decision to make them is a signal you send yourself about the kind of player you're becoming. And also all the small details can compound throughout the entire game. It will help you in that one fight, will lead you to the next, to the next, and to the next. If you improve by 1% every single day, you'll be 37 times better by the end of the year. >> Playing like games that actually matter. Look at what you're doing and don't, you know, just spam games for no reason. Like your deaths don't matter. >> Volume without intention is noise. The worst practice mistakes. Grinding without reviews. Watching without playing. Playing without thinking. The common thread is volume without engagement. One fully intentional game played completely, reviewed honestly, and with one specific focus is worth way more than 10 automated games played on muscle memory while watching the second monitor half the time. This week, one session of deliberate practice, one specific thing you're working on, and after every game, what happened with that one thing? That is the whole practice, and that's what's going to make you better. Chapter 8, the first reward. Near the end of our conversation, after everything we talked about the practice, the psychology, the mistakes, he said something I want to end on. >> If you put in the effort, it matters. And as long as you see that, like as long as you eventually get to see it, I think it just becomes like not like addicting, but like you're like, "Okay, like this matters. Like my time put into this matters." But you also learn not to waste your time put into it as well. >> Once you see that effort matters, once you feel the first reward, you'll never want to stop. The problem is most people quit before it compounds. Not because they stop trying, but because

they change direction before the effort had a time to produce something they could see. The players who climbed are not the most talented. They're not even the ones necessarily working harder. They managed to stick with one thing long enough to see the loop close and then finally get the reward. And then they never want to stop. He also said something about understanding that I've not been able to stop thinking about. Teaching something forces you to understand it. Discussing it outside your echo chamber forces you to defend it. If you can only apply it, you do not really understand it. You're executing a habit. Understanding survives context, habits don't. Talk about this with someone who will engage with it seriously. In the comments, in your friend group, on Discord. Not to share what you learned, to find out what you actually understand versus what you think you understood. That gap is going to surprise you. You're probably not some genius, but neither is Callous. He just stayed under the discomfort longer than anyone else and he hated being bad enough to do something about it.